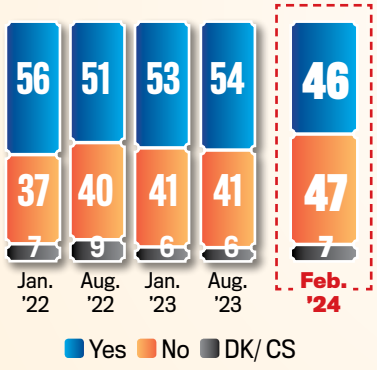
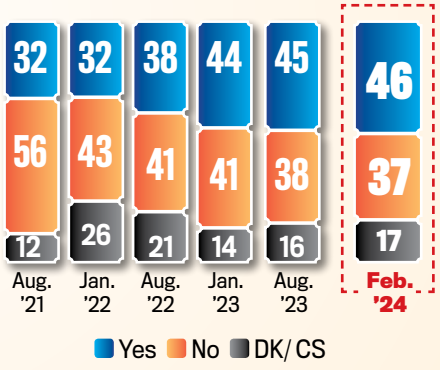
Q. Has the Modi government brought down corruption in India?



Less than half the repondents felt that corruption was down–8 percentage points lower than last time

A high share of respondents think the BJP regime misuses central agencies more than past governments

Q. Do you think the BJP government misuses central agencies such as the ED, CBI andthe I-T department more than previous governments?



All figures in % and rounded off

Could Team Modi see a 2004 redux, when UPA trounced NDA in a surprise outcome? Unlikely, as the Modi-Shah duo is not given to complacency

Compared to the August 2023 MOTN, I.N.D.I.A.'s vote share is down by three percentage points, from 41 per cent to 38.3 per cent now. In terms of seats, the alliance's numbers have dropped from 193 six months ago to 166.

The person most credited with inflicting damage on I.N.D.I.A. is BJP strongman and Union home minister Amit Shah, who has pulled out all the stops to wean away its constituents. At 28.8 per cent, Shah, who has built the BJP into the juggernaut that it currently is and who was the architect of the abrogation of Article 370 in Kashmir, has emerged in this MOTN on top of the list of leaders who are most favoured to succeed Modi as the BJP's prime ministerial candidate. That puts him 4.1 percentage points ahead of Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath, who polled 24.7 per cent votes. Union transport minister Nitin Gadkari comes third, with 16.1 per cent of the respondents backing him.

Interestingly, when vote percentages were dissected, CVoter found that more males voted NDA than females; it was the reverse for I.N.D.I.A. The NDA did have the support of all age groups, but when it came to income levels, the highest support came from the higher income group and, to some extent, the middle income one. The rival alliances were in a close fight for lower income groups. I.N.D.I.A. has the clear support of minorities, but the NDA could still muster the support of 20 per cent of the Muslims. Among the Other Backward Classes (OBCs) and forward castes, the NDA has a clear lead, but the race narrows down considerably when it comes to Scheduled Castes and Tribes. Likewise, the NDA seems to have the urban vote firmly in its pocket but will have to compete fiercely with I.N.D.I.A. for the rural vote, going by MOTN numbers.

WHAT'S NOT SHINING

While both Modi and the BJP come out largely shining in this MOTN, they need to heed some warning signs, especially on the economic front. Asked about the biggest achievements of the NDA government, its handling of the Covid-19 pandemic still tops the list for the fifth consecutive MOTN beginning January 2022. Despite the grand inauguration of the Ram temple in Ayodhya and the development of the Kashi temple corridor earlier, they come second in the list, even though there is a rise of six percentage points from August 2023. Corruption-free governance and revocation of Article 370 are third and fourth, respectively. Interestingly, infrastructure and social welfare programmes are not high in people's perception of the government's successes.

It is, however, in the responses to the government's biggest failures that the signs of worry for the current dispensation lie. Price rise continues to dominate the list, followed by unemployment. Ironically, the government's handling of Covid-19 is third on the list of failures, and the lack of economic growth fourth. Add the three issues—inflation, jobs and growth—and the ruling BJP has a worrisome 54 per cent seeing the government doing poorly on economic issues. The current survey also reveals some paradoxes if you analyse the responses to the more granular questions on economic and social issues.